

Mayor & Vice Mayor — Kaya Seed Presentation Card

Occasion: Presentation of hand-collected kaya (榧) seeds in a self-made sugi (cedar) box with kintsugi gold-flake seam.

Three voices, three timescales — keep them visually separated:

Location	Voice	Timescale / Meaning
Outside of card / lid	Tanka (gold)	Future (100 years)
Inside lid (smaller)	Kintsugi line	Present (the project)
Beside the seeds	Scent haiku + skin remedy	Now (this moment)
Bottom of the box	Cedar sawdust from local mill	Community (village hands)

1. Tanka — outside of card / box lid

榧の実を 手づから集め 御杖村にて
百年先の 木陰を植える

*Kaya no mi wo / tezukara atsume / Mitsue nite /
hyakunen-saki no / kokage wo ueru*

Kaya seeds, gathered by my own hand, here in Mitsue —
planting the shade of a hundred years from now.

2. Kintsugi line — inside lid (smaller, in gold)

金継ぎのごとく — 割れ目を金にて継ぎ、村を強くする

Kintsugi no gotoku — wareme wo kin nite tsugi, mura wo tsuyoku suru

Like kintsugi — joining the cracks with gold,
making the village stronger.

English line (other side of card):

Like kintsugi, we mend what was broken with gold —
and what is mended is stronger than what was whole.

3. Scent haiku & skin remedy — beside the seeds (smallest)

掌に 榧の香ひそむ 恵みかな

Tenohira ni / kaya no ka hisomu / megumi kana

In the palm —
kaya's quiet scent hidden,
a small blessing.

English note (for inside the lid, near the seeds):

Rub a seed gently between your palms —
the warm oil softens the skin and leaves its scent for hours.
Kaya oil has been a quiet remedy in Japan since ancient times:
the seed is both gift and small medicine.

Japanese companion line (alongside, in smaller script):

古より、榧の油は肌をやさしく潤し、香りを長く残すと伝えられる。
Inishie yori, kaya no abura wa hada wo yasashiku uruoshi, kaori wo nagaku nokosu to tsutaerareru.

Since ancient times, kaya oil has been said to gently soften the skin
and let its fragrance linger.

Suggested Card Layout (folded A6 or B7)

榧の実を 手づから集め
三津江にて
百年先の 木陰を植える

← Tanka, gold ink
on dark indigo / sumi
(front face)

— opens to —

金継ぎのごとく
割れ目を金にて継ぎ
村を強くする

← Kintsugi line, gold
(left inside)

Like kintsugi,
we mend what was broken
with gold —
and what is mended is
stronger than what was whole.

← English mirror
(right inside)

— small card beside the seeds —

掌に
榧の香ひそむ
恵みかな

Rub between palms —
the warm oil softens
the skin; the scent
lingers for hours.

Variant — for the Forestry Team

Same three verses, but **swap the front-face dedication**:

杉の箱に 榧の実を入れて 森の手へ
切るは今日 植えるは百年 共にゆく

*Sugi no hako ni / kaya no mi wo irete / mori no te e /
kuru wa kyō / ueru wa hyakunen / tomo ni yuku*

Into a cedar box, kaya seeds — for the hands of the forest.
Today we cut; for a hundred years we plant; we go together.

The cedar box itself carries the meaning more directly for the forestry team — the wood is *their* wood, the seam is *their* repair, and the seeds are *their* next century of work. Their box's kintsugi seam can be larger and more visible than the mayor's — they'll appreciate the honesty.

Material & Making Notes

Box (sugi / cedar, self-made):

- Saw or split a single sugi panel, rejoin with clear two-part epoxy + real gold flakes (kinpun 金粉) suspended in the resin.
- Sand the seam flush, but leave it *very slightly* proud — real kintsugi sits raised, not flat.
- Leave the cedar unfinished or rub with camellia oil (椿油). The cedar's scent will mingle with the kaya's when the box is opened.

Bed of cedar sawdust (bottom of the box):

- Sawdust from a local Mitsue mill — from the owner Rob knows personally.
- Lay a soft bed of fresh cedar sawdust in the bottom of the box; rest the three kaya seeds on top.
- The cedar sawdust scent will mingle with the kaya's the moment the lid is lifted — a layered, immediate sensory greeting.
- **Symbolic layer:** the new growth (kaya seeds) rests on the bed of what is being cut (cedar). And the bed itself is the gift of a community member — so the village is literally inside the box, under the seeds. The community is not described in the card; it is felt when the lid opens.
- Use *fresh* sawdust (collected near the time of the meeting) — older

sawdust loses its scent quickly.

Card:

- Gold ink (or gold foil hot-stamp) on deep indigo or sumi-black washi.
- If handwritten: fude pen with gold ink. Imperfect is better than printed.
- Three seeds per recipient — echoes 三 in 三津江.

Kaya oil — folk use to remember when presenting:

- When a kaya seed is rubbed between warm palms, a small amount of oil is released along with the fragrance.
- That oil has been used in Japan since ancient times as a gentle skin remedy — for dryness, irritation, and as a mild fragrance.
- Mention this quietly when handing over the seeds, especially if the vice mayor takes one in hand. The gift then carries an immediate, physical kindness alongside the symbolic one.

Spoken framing (only if it lands naturally):

"The trees we cut for this project are cedar.
The trees we plant back are kaya — slower, more valuable, more patient.
That is the trade I want to make with Mitsue."

"Rub one between your palms — the oil is gentle on the skin,
and the scent will stay with you for the rest of the day."

"The bed under the seeds is cedar sawdust from [mill owner's name]'s
mill, here in Mitsue. Even the ground the seeds rest on comes from
the hands of this village."

Drafted for the mayor meeting, May 2026.

Personal — not for publication.